

Session 2: The Main Themes of the Torah

Key Takeaways

- Genesis 1-11 serves as the introduction to the Hebrew Bible and establishes a pattern of themes that are repeated and developed throughout the rest of the story, including Ezekiel.
- The precise design and arrangement of each section of Ezekiel echoes the Bible's thematic melody introduced in the early chapters of Genesis.

Starting Point #2: The Story of the Covenant and the Prophets

1. The promise of Eden and God's royal priests foolishly fail.
 - God brings order out of chaos and appoints humans as royal-priests in a cosmic temple where Heaven and Earth are one.
 - Humans foolishly rebel, and they are exiled from sacred space out into the wilderness, where chaos and violence keep re-cycling into wider circles of destruction leading to Babylon's rise, fall, and scattering.
2. God chooses one family from the scattering of Babylon (see Gen. 11:10-32) and promises that through this family, he will restore the blessing of Eden to all nations (God's blessing and covenant with Abraham in Gen. 12, 15, 17).
3. As the family grows, God rescues them from slavery in Egypt and invites all of them to become his covenant partners and priestly representatives to the nations.
 - Exodus 19-24: God calls Israel to obey the Torah in order to become priests to the nations.
 - Leviticus 26: God promises blessing for covenant obedience and increasing levels of curse leading to exile for covenant disobedience.
4. Moses as the archetypal prophet leads the people toward the land, and he warns them of the dire need for covenant faithfulness.
 - Deuteronomy 27-30: Moses warns Israel of the consequences of covenant failure—the blessing and the curse.
 - Deuteronomy 31-32: Yahweh and Moses warn Israel that they're going to be unfaithful to the covenant and turn toward other gods for help. Moses' poem of "testimony" (Deut. 32) is a preview of Israel's story in the land.
5. The family as a whole consistently fails as God's covenant partners, so God raises up a king and promises that through his line a future descendant will realize the promises made to Abraham and Israel.
 - God's covenant with David: 2 Samuel 7; 1 Chronicles 17; Psalms 2, 132, 72.
 - God promises a royal descendant who will come from David's line and restore the Eden blessing to the nations.
6. David's descendants fail: 1-2 Kings.

- David's sons are led astray through idolatry, money, sex, and power. They run Israel, the temple, and Jerusalem into the ground.
- Babylon arises to conquer the whole ancient Near East, and God allows them to overpower Jerusalem and force David's line into slavery.

7. The scrolls of the prophets link back to earlier in the story and focus on key moments when Yahweh raised up more Moses-like mediators between God and the people.

- Isaiah 1:2 opens with the same words as Moses' song in Deuteronomy 32.
- Jeremiah resists his calling as a prophet with lame excuses that imitate Moses' lame excuses at the burning bush (Jer. 1:1-10 echoes Exod. 3-4).
- Ezekiel's vision of the divine chariot echoes Moses' vision of Yahweh in the burning bush (Exod. 3) and on Mount Sinai (Exod. 19-24).

The Essential Plot Conflict of Ezekiel

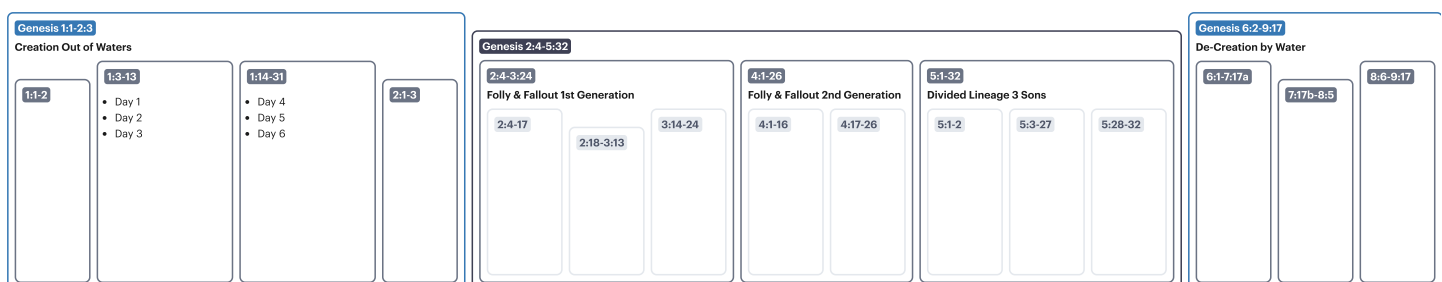
The Story: God appoints Abraham, Israel, and David's line as the way he will restore the Eden-blessing to the nations and so demonstrate his character and justice (see Gen. 12:1-3; Exod. 19:1-6; 2 Sam. 7; and Ps. 72).

The Crisis: Every generation of Israel and its king breaks the covenant and fails to faithfully represent Yahweh to the nations. Even the remnant of Judah begins an irreversible descent into exile and destruction.

The Questions Raised: Would Yahweh really allow people to be decimated and sent into exile? Would he really destroy the temple, his chosen place to live? What about his promises to Abraham and David? Is there any hope for the future of the covenant? How will Israel ever become a faithful covenant partner? Will the Heaven-on-Earth dream of Eden ever be realized?

Starting Point #3: The Thematic Melody of the TaNaK

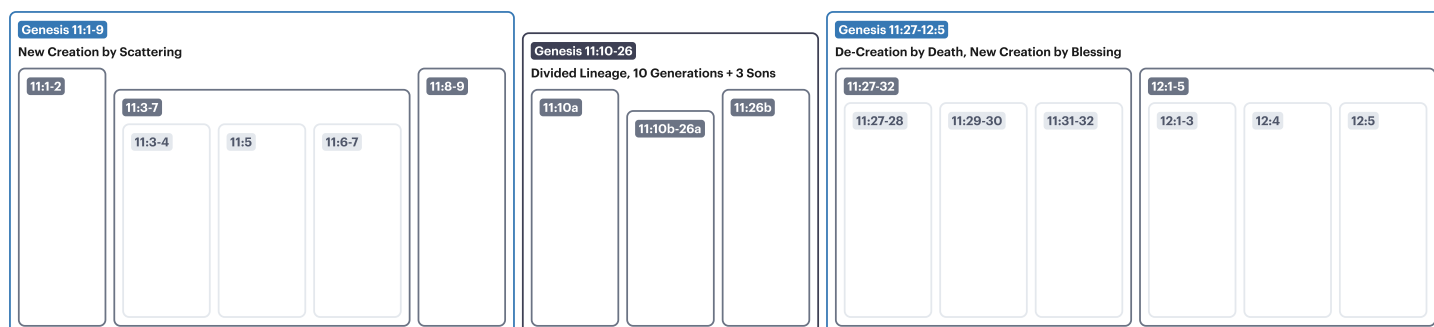
The literary organization of Genesis 1:1-11:26, both in its design and the main themes explored in the narratives, forms the template for the organization of the TaNaK. So then, to truly grasp what the entire TaNaK is about, we need to recap the story so far, as it's presented in Genesis 1-11 (adapted from D.A. Teeter, personal communication and his "Biblical Symmetry and Its Modern Detractors" paper delivered at the 2019 Congress of the International Organization for the Study of the Old Testament).



Genesis 1:1-9:17. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).



Genesis 6:1-11:9. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).



Genesis 11:1-12:5. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).

These thematic cycles set up a narrative pattern and thematic melody that re-cycles with each following generation as well as developing and advancing. The basic melody goes like this.

1. Creation and Blessing

- God brings order/life/blessing out of chaos/waters/death/curse.
- Key words: life, blessing, create, establish, seed, sprout, grow, fruit, fruitful, and multiply; seven, fullness, and oath (all spelled שבע)
- Key images: dry land, refuge, safety, order

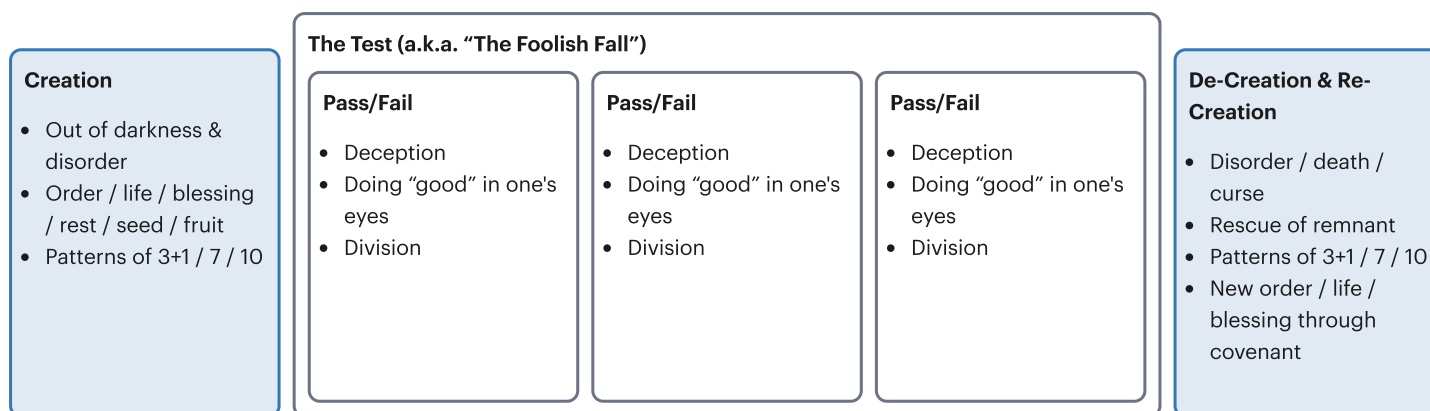
2. Folly, Test, and Failure (a.k.a. "The Foolish Fall")

- God invites a chosen human partner to share in the order/life/blessing, which places a decision/test of their trustworthiness on the table.
- God's chosen partner fails/succeeds the test, usually involving deception/division/violence.
- The same person/next generation faces their own opportunity and test, and fails/succeeds, usually involving an intensified expression of deception/division/violence.
- The escalating sequence of tests and failures leads to a separation between the key characters so that one person or family splits off from the rest and is chosen by God for a new future.

3. De-Creation and Re-Creation

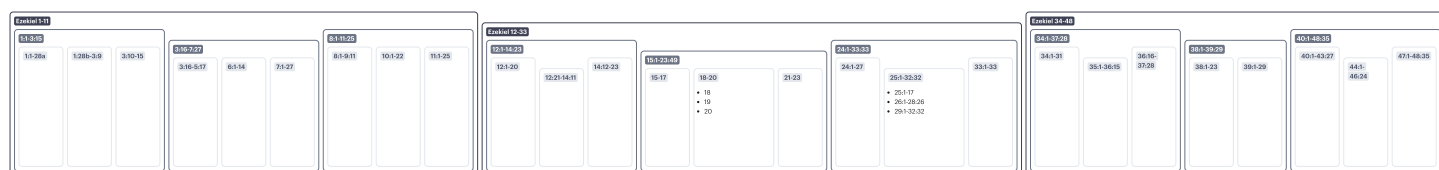
- De-creation: God brings about an inversion of #1 above, usually an escalation of chaos/death/curse.
- Out of that de-creation, God chooses/preserves a remnant/seed and begins a new movement of re-creation through them (often marked by covenants and wordplays on the Hebrew root שבע, "seven/fullness/oath" or "covenant," ברית).

4. Press Repeat



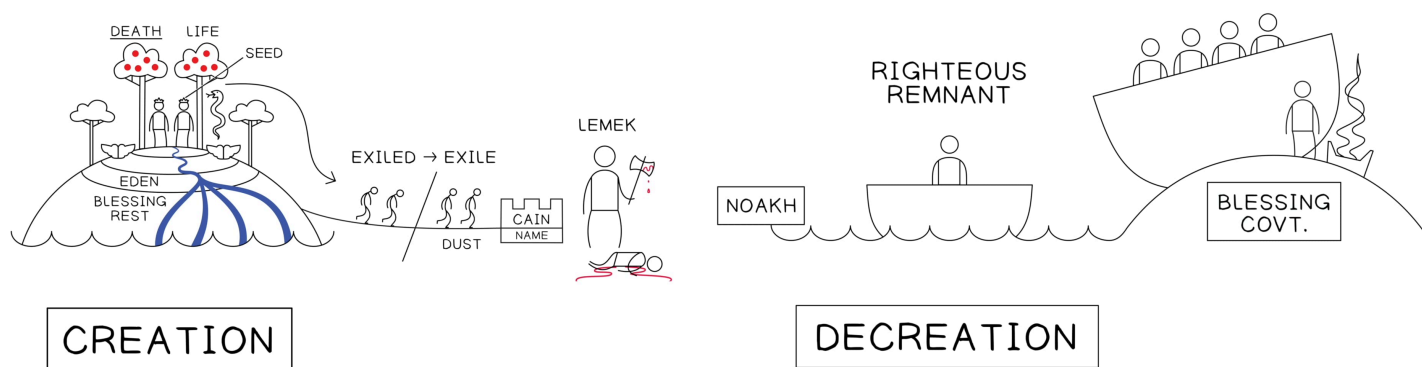
Genesis 1:1-11:26. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Abraham (2021).

The Ezekiel scroll is organized according to this same thematic melody, as the cycle replays itself on the macro-level, medium-level, and micro-level of each part of the story.



Ezekiel 1-48. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Ezekiel (2021).

Exile and Covenant in Genesis



Exile and Covenant in Genesis. Illustration created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Ezekiel (2021).

Reflection Question

How does familiarity with the cycle of themes from Genesis help us understand Ezekiel?